

Soul Mates

It is to them that Advani turns for advice



Vijai Kapoor The former Delhi Lt governor who runs through matters relating to policy and administration is now a special invitee to the BJP National Executive.



Ajit Doval Was IB director when Advani was home minister and is a key adviser on security. In an NDA set-up, he could be the national security adviser.



Anil Baijal The former home secretary remains an Advani favourite and draws on his vast administrative experience to advise on a range of issues.



S. Gurumurthy The chartered accountant-cum-party ideologue is a key aide on economic issues. Was the brain behind Advani's tirade against money stashed abroad.



S. Kulkarni The former left-wing journalist is chief political adviser, speechwriter, "ideas man" and also oversees Advani's popular website.



Deepak Chopra Left his cushy job with an MNC to join Advani during the Rath Yatra and has stayed on since. Manages everything from meetings to tours and travels.

Within the party, less than a handful enjoy Advani's complete trust. Among them are Arun Jaitley, Venkaiah Naidu and Ananth Kumar. Jaitley opted out of a poll fight to take charge of the campaign, including what goes in the print and electronic media. Kumar is busy fighting his own election in Bangalore. Naidu, like Jaitley, opted out of a fight and is the party's pointsman for sewing up alliances, especially in the South. According to someone in the know, though there are many offering advice to Advani, he still lacks an aide to help him take a final call and position himself as a brand.



ADVANI PERHAPS MISSES THE REASSURING PRESENCE OF ATAL BIHARI VAJPAYEE

moderate. The vision thing, though rich in its digital content, doesn't contain an economic message that captures the anxiety and hopelessness of the times. Even the manifesto, hardly antediluvian, does not contain a clearly spelt out economic agenda, that too at a time when the world is in the midst of the Great Recession, when the most feted apostle of change—also the one who inspired Advani's techno-savvy campaign—is devoting the first days of power to the restoration of the economy. What is Advani's economic doctrine? "There are many things which should be done by the government, and they need not be part of the manifesto," he says. The manifesto, though, says that there won't be foreign direct investment (FDI) in retail. That may largely be due to the compulsion to keep small-time traders, a traditional constituency of the BJP, happy. "We must shift the emphasis towards the agriculture sector. You cannot have a booming economy and thousands of farmers committing suicide. It has never happened before even in India. And in spite of our stand on FDI, we have always been against the licence-permit raj. When the Narasimha Rao government opened the market, we welcomed it. The tendency to copy everything Western is not good for India."

"Isn't there a disconnect? The moderniser seems to have no matching economic vision. Isn't it a bit strange as the Right has historically won the economic argument?"

"I know there is some disparity."

"Isn't it in your politics too to some extent. Candidate Advani comes across as a political moderate who hardly